Faxian spent the next six years in India and visited many sites associated with the Buddha, such as Lumbini and Rajagriha. It took him three more years to return to China by sea. He took back with him many texts ‘unknown in the land of Han’ aboard a large ship carrying ‘more than 200 men’, braving the terrors of tempests and his ship springing a leak. He travelled via Ceylon and Java, where, he writes, ‘various forms of error and Brahminism are flourishing, while Buddhism in it is not worth speaking of’. After spending years translating texts, he died at age eighty-six.

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Two centuries later came Xuanzang. Born in a conservative Confucian family near Chang’an, he followed his brother into the Buddhist monastic life at the age of thirteen. A precocious boy seemingly blessed with a photographic memory, Xuanzang mastered his material so well that he was ordained a priest when he was only twenty. Disenchanted with the quality of Buddhist texts and teachers available to him, and ‘stirred up by the recollection of Faxian’, he decided to go west to India, to the cradle and thriving centre of Buddhism itself. He intended to ‘question the sages on points that troubled his mind’ and to return with authentic knowledge and Buddhist scriptures.

Xuanzang was twenty-six when he set out on a year-long journey full of peril and adventure. He had prepared for it by learning basic travel phrases in many languages from foreigners in Xian.[10] He rode alone much of the way on his horse, crossing great deserts, mountains and rivers, braving hail and snowstorms, and, like Faxian before him, was often guided by nothing more than the bones lying on the way. Passing a desert, ‘all sorts of demon shapes and strange goblins’ closed in on him, vanishing only after he recited a Chinese mantra. Then, riding his horse, he accidentally dropped his water pouch and lost all of his drinking water. After going five days without a drop of water, he tells us, ‘his stomach was racked with a burning heat’. He was close to death when he finally stumbled across a small oasis and found water.

Having avoided death by dehydration, he went on to escape robbers, pesky kings and other colourful characters that seem right out of B-grade